

Case study

the 1970s. He remembers facing a storm of criticism from his peer group. All that is history now.

In a new, globalised India, the search for beauty is a socially-sanctioned pastime. And aesthetic considerations have put many an average nose out of joint. "Aesthetic surgery is big all over the world," points out Pandya. "With rising prosperity, Indians are now very much in sync with their Western counterparts in their penchant for a well-defined nose." Nose jobs top the charts in the West, too. "But there the goal of the procedure is to shorten, tilt or lower a prominent nose. For Indians, this is usually the opposite," he adds. The most common changes mean making the tip pointed, narrowing the bridge, the wide bony part and nostrils, reducing the base and the angle between nose and lip. The direct inspiration, of course, comes from Bollywood. "Plastic surgery in India began in full-swing in the 1980s as movie stars and fashion icons went for cosmetic surgery," says Pandya.

With it all, the nose has come under attack. "It's the most prominent landmark of your face and virtually dictates your facial expression and personality," says Gupta, who formed the aesthetic surgery unit at Gangaram Hospital five years ago. A recent survey done by the American Aesthetic Surgery Association reveals that people are more conscious of their face than the rest of their body, as earlier believed. And the nose is the centre of attention



Surgery: Reconstructive

Details: **Crooked and off-centred noses often result from injuries, with splayed bones and a damaged nasal support mechanism. Surgery can improve both appearance and breathing.**

Surgery: Aesthetic

Details: **The preoperative photo shows a nose that projected too far from the face and had a drooping tip. Surgery restored facial harmony by moving the nasal tip back toward the face.**



on a face. "This explains the rising popularity of the procedure," analyses Choudhary.

This year, Choudhary undertook a study to probe the reasons why patients go in for rhinoplasties. About 30 patients were given a simple questionnaire and the results analysed. "The results show that the two main age groups—those in their 20s and 30s and the 40-plus—have very different reasons and priorities when it comes to nose jobs," he says. While the bulk of patients in both categories mentioned "to boost self-confidence", it was heavily underscored by the ageing group. For the younger generation, "to increase professional opportunities" and "to attract potential partners" featured prominently, after self-esteem.

It's hard to separate the wheat of "self-esteem" from the chaff of "feel good". And both translate into career success for men, especially in cities and sectors that are linked to the globalised world of work. "Being a

part of the global city, a lot of Bangalore men, for instance, want to look and feel young," says Venkatesh. "They feel good looks are integral to their career growth." The nose has been an area of fascination for the plastic surgeon. "Men with broad, small, slumped or crooked noses appear to have a low self-esteem and end up being less productive in their careers," he adds. A case in point is his patient, Imran Wajid, 24, a Bangalore businessman. An accidental swing of a cricket bat had left Wajid's nose crooked and made him self-conscious about the way he looked. "The nose job was such a transformation for me that I was jumping with joy when I first saw myself in the mirror," recalls Wajid.

The surge in rhinoplasty demand is matched by the improvement in treatment modalities: from finer suture materials, better understanding of anatomy and physiology, availability of good quality implants to refinement in surgical techniques.

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NEW PREMIUM ON THE NOSE

MOST-CITED REASONS FOR SURGERY

	AGE 20s-30s	AGE 40s-50s
To boost my self-confidence	40%	5%
Enhance my value in the marriage market	30%	15%
To be more accepted socially	15%	5%
My nose doesn't give me a career edge	5%	10%

Source: Institute of Aesthetic & Reconstructive Surgery, Max Healthcare, New Delhi; a six-month study on 30 patients by Dr Sunil Choudhary, 2009

